

NORTHBOUND ® · PORTLAND, OREGON

SITE PDF · APRIL 2026

— A DESIGN STUDIO FOR THE OUTDOORS

BUILT, USED' AND BRANDED.

A design studio working with gear companies, apparel labels, guide services, and the people who make them. Branding, identity, and digital — that's the whole offer.

NORTHBOUND STUDIO

HELLO@NORTHBOUND.STUDIO

ESTABLISHED 2019

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NORTHBOUND ® · PORTLAND, OREGON · EST. 2019

N° 01 / HOMEPAGE

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Working with gear companies, apparel
labels, guide services, and the people
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and digital — that's the whole offer.

[See the work →](#)[What we do →](#)

[View project →](#)

CORDILLINE

APPAREL
·
IDENTITY
& WEB

A heritage apparel brand, modernized
without losing its weight.

2025 APPAREL · IDENTITY & WEB

— FEATURED · CONTINUED

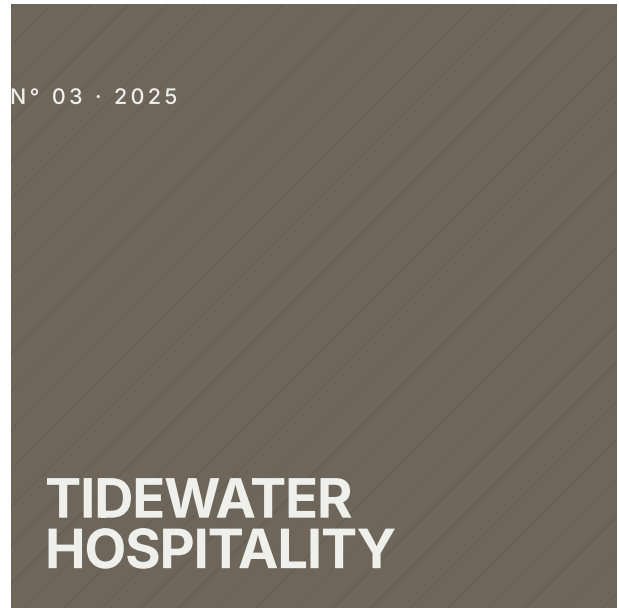
N° 02-03 / 09



FOOD & OUTDOOR RETAIL · BRAND
SYSTEM

**A trail food company built
around one idea — you eat
better when you carry less.**

[View project →](#)



GUIDE SERVICES · IDENTITY & DIGITAL

**A new identity for a third-
generation Oregon coast
outfitter.**

[View project →](#)

— ABOUT THE STUDIO

A STUDIO FOR ONE INDUSTRY. ON PURPOSE.

Northbound was founded in 2019 by Maren Hollis, after a decade designing gear and apparel for outdoor brands. The studio works with one kind of client — outdoor companies — because depth beats breadth when you actually know a category.

Branding, identity, and digital.
Project-based engagements.
Selective by design.

[Meet the studio →](#)

STUDIO.JPG — 2026

STUDIO ENVIRONMENT,
NORTHEAST PORTLAND

01 Cordilline	02 FIELD PROVISIONS	03 TIDEWATER	04 COMMON PATH
05 Marlow Studies	06 Heron & Wells	07 SALTWATER SOCIETY	08 BOULDER CACHE
09 Tarn Goods	10 Forest Table	11 NORTHERN BELLWETHER	12 Lithic Trail Co.

— AWARDS &
RECOGNITIONS

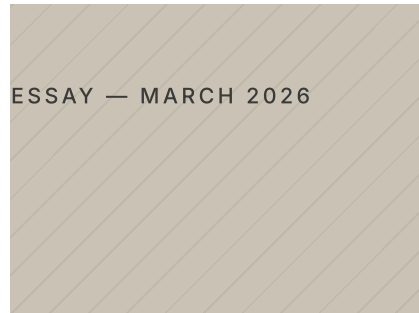
SELECTED WORK,
RECOGNIZED.

2025	Communication Arts — Typography Annual
2025	Brand New — Noted (Cordilline)
2024	Type Directors Club — Certificate of Typographic Excellence
2024	AIGA 50/50 Books — Honorable Mention
2023	Communication Arts — Design Annual
2023	The Webby Awards — Nominee, Outdoor & Adventure
2022	Brand New — Noted (Field Provisions)
2021	Print Magazine — Regional Design Annual

— FROM THE JOURNAL

NOTES FROM THE STUDIO.

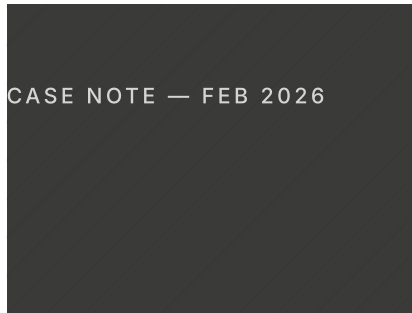
[Read the journal →](#)



ESSAY — MARCH 2026

ESSAY · MARCH 2026

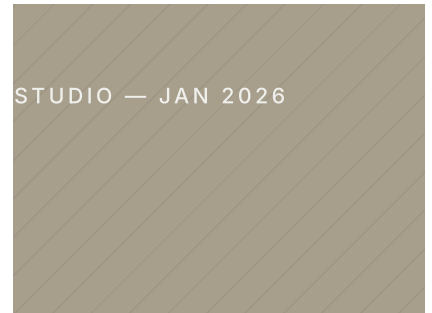
Why the outdoor industry keeps redesigning the same logo.



CASE NOTE — FEB 2026

CASE NOTE · FEBRUARY 2026

Building a brand system for a guide service that's been running since 1962.



STUDIO — JAN 2026

STUDIO · JANUARY 2026

On working with one industry, on purpose.

SEVEN YEARS. ONE INDUSTRY. SELECTED WORK FROM 2019 TO TODAY.

Branding, identity, and digital for outdoor companies. Project-based, scoped, selective. Northbound takes on roughly twelve engagements a year.



APPAREL · IDENTITY, BRAND SYSTEM, WEB

Cordilline

A heritage apparel brand, modernized without losing its weight.

2025



FOOD & OUTDOOR RETAIL · BRAND, PACKAGING, WEB

Field Provisions

A trail food company built around carrying less and eating better.

2024



GUIDE SERVICES · IDENTITY, DIGITAL,
PRINT

Tidewater Hospitality

A new identity for a third-generation Oregon coast outfitter.

2025



OUTDOOR NONPROFIT · BRAND SYSTEM,
WEB

Common Path

A trail-stewardship nonprofit, rebuilt around the people who do the work.

2023



OUTDOOR MEDIA · IDENTITY, EDITORIAL
DESIGN

Marlow Studies

A small-format magazine about long walks, slow rivers, and the people who write about them.

2024

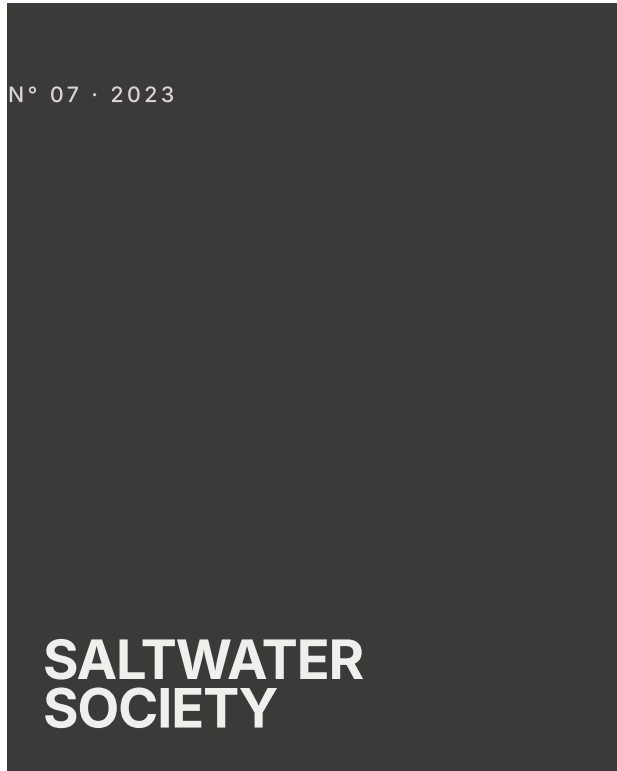


APPAREL · IDENTITY, WEB

Heron & Wells

A waxed-canvas goods maker, repositioned for a second decade.

2022

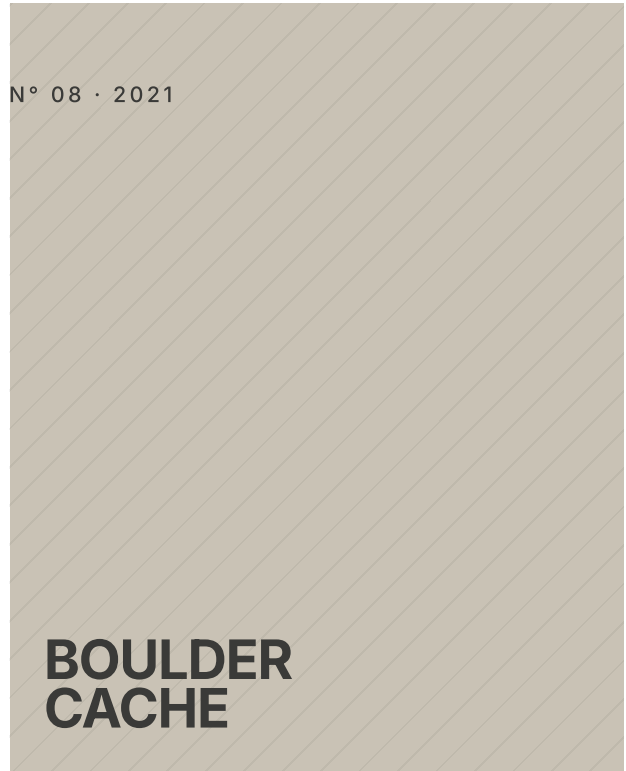


OUTDOOR RETAIL · BRAND SYSTEM,
DIGITAL

Saltwater Society

A specialty surf and salt-water shop, treated
like a magazine.

2023



CLIMBING GEAR · IDENTITY, PACKAGING

Boulder Cache

A small-batch climbing hardware company,
built around one founder's notebook.

2021



HARDGOODS · IDENTITY, WEB, RETAIL
ENVIRONMENTS

Tarn Goods

An alpine goods brand, named after the
lakes you only reach on foot.

2020

BRANDING, IDENTITY, AND DIGITAL FOR THE OUTDOORS. THAT'S THE OFFER.

Northbound runs a small offer on purpose. Three core practices, applied to one kind of client. Every engagement starts with the brand and ends with the build.

01 · BRANDING

THE STRATEGY AND THE SYSTEM.

Brand work at Northbound is research-led and product-aware. We start by understanding the company — what it makes, who buys it, where it sits in the category, and what's actually true about it.

From there, we build the system: positioning, voice, naming when needed, and the visual identity that holds it all.

BRAND STRATEGY & POSITIONING

AUDIENCE AND CATEGORY RESEARCH

NAMING

VISUAL IDENTITY SYSTEMS

VOICE AND COPY DIRECTION

BRAND GUIDELINES

BRAND SYSTEM — ARTIFACTS



LOGO
TYPE
COLOR

02 · IDENTITY & PRINT

THE ARTIFACTS THAT CARRY THE BRAND.

Logos, marks, packaging, lookbooks, hangtags, retail signage, catalogs. The objects a brand actually shows up as. Northbound brings a product designer's eye to brand artifacts — every detail is treated as something that has to function in the world.

LOGOS AND MARKS

PACKAGING DESIGN

PRINT COLLATERAL AND EDITORIAL

CATALOGS AND LOOKBOOKS

RETAIL SIGNAGE AND ENVIRONMENTS

HANGTAGS AND PRODUCT GRAPHICS

IDENTITY & PRINT — ARTIFACTS



**PACK·
LOOKBOOK·
TAGS**

03 · DIGITAL

WEBSITES THAT HOLD UP.

Brand websites, ecommerce, and digital systems built on modern frameworks. Northbound writes the copy, designs the system, and ships the build. We keep digital scope tight — most clients don't need a hundred pages, they need ten that work.

BRAND WEBSITES

SHOPIFY AND HEADLESS ECOMMERCE

EDITORIAL AND CONTENT SITES

DESIGN SYSTEMS AND COMPONENT LIBRARIES

COPY AND CONTENT STRATEGY

PERFORMANCE AND ACCESSIBILITY

DIGITAL — SITE SYSTEMS

SITES· SHOPS· SYSTEMS

— HOW WE WORK

FOUR PHASES. NO FIXED TIMELINE.

01

INTAKE

We start with a conversation. What the company makes, what it needs, what's already working. Most engagements begin with a one-page brief.

02

STRATEGY

The thinking before the design. Positioning, voice, audience, and the framework the rest of the work hangs on.

03

DESIGN

The brand system, identity artifacts, and digital design — built in parallel where it makes sense, in sequence where it doesn't.

04

BUILD & HAND-OFF

The website goes live. The brand guidelines get delivered. The team gets trained on the system. We stay in touch.

— A NOTE ON ENGAGEMENTS

A NOTE ON ENGAGEMENTS.

Northbound takes on roughly twelve projects a year. We don't do retainer work, ongoing content, or paid media. Most engagements run between eight and sixteen weeks, scoped to the project and the client. If we're not the right fit, we'll say so.

A STUDIO FOR ONE INDUSTRY. THE OUTDOORS.

Northbound is a Portland design studio working with outdoor companies. We started in 2019 with a narrow idea — design for one industry, and only that industry — and seven years in, the thesis has held.

— THE STUDIO

WE STARTED INSIDE THE INDUSTRY WE NOW SERVE.

Northbound was founded by Maren Hollis in 2019, after a decade designing gear and apparel for outdoor brands. The studio's first office was a corner of a screen-printing shop in Northeast Portland. The second was a converted woodworking space three blocks east. The current studio is in the same neighborhood. We haven't moved far.

The thesis hasn't changed either. Northbound works with outdoor companies — gear makers, apparel labels, guide services, retailers, and the occasional nonprofit — because depth beats breadth when you actually know a category. Our clients don't have to explain what a softshell is, or why the seam placement on a pack matters, or what makes one trail brand feel honest and another feel like a costume. We already know.

The work is brand-first — strategy, identity, and digital. It always starts from the product, because that's where the founder started.

PORTRAIT — MAREN HOLLIS

STUDIO PORTRAIT,
WORKING

— THE FOUNDER

MAREN HOLLIS.

Maren spent the first years of her career at Foothill Supply Co., a small Portland outdoor brand where she did everything — designed

packs and softgoods, wrote the catalog, shot the lookbook. From there she moved to Heyburn, where she led product design across technical apparel and hardgoods for nearly a decade.

She opened Northbound in 2019 with a single thesis: design for the outdoor industry, and only the outdoor industry. The studio's editorial sensibility — the typography, the restraint, the way the work reads — comes directly from those years inside the catalog and the gear room.

She still sketches every brand by hand before it goes digital.

— WHAT WE BELIEVE

A FEW THINGS WE HOLD TO.

01 DEPTH BEATS BREADTH.

We work with one industry because knowing it well changes the work. There's no version of "we also do outdoor" that produces the same result.

02 THE BRAND STARTS AT THE PRODUCT.

Every good outdoor brand starts with something physical — a pack, a parka, a route, a place. We build out from there.

03 RESTRAINT IS A FEATURE.

The industry is loud enough already. Our work tends toward quiet because clarity is harder than ornament.

04 WE DON'T DO COSTUME.

There's a way of writing about the outdoors that sounds like it's auditioning for a magazine cover. We don't do that. The brands we admire don't either.

05 SCOPE IS A KINDNESS.

Tight scopes make better work and better relationships. Most engagements are eight to sixteen weeks. We say no often.

— STUDIO

COLOPHON

LOCATION

Northbound Studio
Northeast Portland, Oregon
By appointment

TEAM

Maren Hollis, Founder & Creative Director.
Plus a rotating cast of trusted collaborators — designers, photographers, and writers who've been part of the studio's work over the years.

RECOGNITION

Communication Arts
Brand New
Type Directors Club
AIGA 50 Books / 50 Covers
Print Magazine
The Webby Awards

NOTES FROM THE STUDIO. ESSAYS, CASE NOTES, AND THE OCCASIONAL OPINION.

Long-form writing about brand, the outdoors, and the work of building one inside the other. Published when there's something worth saying.

— ALL ENTRIES

SHOWING 08 / 08

ESSAY — MARCH 2026

ESSAY · MARCH 2026

Why the outdoor industry keeps redesigning the same logo.

A category-wide habit, examined. Mountains, sans-serifs, and the gravitational pull of the obvious.

[Read the piece →](#)

CASE NOTE — FEB 2026

CASE NOTE · FEBRUARY 2026

Building a brand system for a guide service that's been running since 1962.

What changes when the brand is older than most of its customers.



STUDIO — JAN 2026

STUDIO · JANUARY 2026

On working with one industry, on purpose.

The thesis behind the studio, seven years in.

ESSAY — DEC 2025

ESSAY · DECEMBER 2025

A short defense of the catalog.

Print isn't dead. It's just sitting on the coffee table doing the work the website forgot how to do.

CRAFT — NOV 2025

CRAFT · NOVEMBER 2025

How we write product copy for gear we'd actually carry.

Specificity, restraint, and the long, slow death of "engineered for adventure."



STUDIO · OCTOBER 2025

Conversations with the people we work with: Heron & Wells.

A waxed-canvas goods maker on heritage, restraint, and
second decades.

ESSAY — SEP 2025

ESSAY · SEPTEMBER 2025

The case against accent colors.

A note on neutral palettes, signal-to-noise ratios, and why the loudest color is usually the wrong one.



PROCESS · AUGUST 2025

What a Northbound brand strategy doc actually looks like.

Pulling back the curtain on the document that runs every project.

TELL US ABOUT THE PROJECT.

Northbound takes on roughly twelve projects a year. If you're working on something in the outdoors — a brand, a relaunch, a digital build — we'd like to hear about it.

YOUR NAME

COMPANY

EMAIL

WHAT KIND OF COMPANY IS IT?

Gear / hardgoods



WHAT ARE YOU WORKING ON?

A sentence or three is plenty.



APPROXIMATE BUDGET

—



TIMELINE

e.g. Q3 2026

Send the brief →

STUDIO

Northbound ®

Northeast Portland, Oregon

DIRECT

PRESS

[\[email protected\]](#)

SOCIAL

[Instagram](#)[LinkedIn](#)

— WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

We read every brief that comes through. If the project is a fit, we'll get back to you within a week with a few questions and next steps. If it's not, we'll tell you that too — and try to point you toward someone who'd be a better match.